Even many Republicans, conservatives among them, feared a backlash at the polls because of the recession; without the faith I had that the tax cuts would recharge the economy, they began pressing me to raise taxes and increase spending. In short, as some reporters wrote, my honeymoon with Congress seemed over.

We had to withdraw a plan to cut billions of dollars in waste and fraud from the Social Security system—among other abuses, we'd discovered monthly Social Security checks were being sent to eighty-five hundred people who'd been dead an average of eighty-one months—after the Democrats began accusing us of plotting to throw senior citizens to the wolves. (Later on, we worked out a bipartisan program that assured the system's integrity for decades to come.) Then, *The Atlantic Monthly* published an article in which David Stockman, the director of the Office of Management and Budget, was quoted as criticizing the economic recovery program and saying it wasn't going to work. Ed Meese and others on the White House senior staff (as well as Nancy) urged me to ask for Stockman's resignation as a turncoat.

I invited him for lunch at the White House. I ate my meal, he didn't touch his. Stockman offered his resignation, but said that the author of the article was a friend of his who had published comments he had meant to be private; I refused his resignation. Although I do not necessarily regret my decision, he later wrote some things about our economic recovery program that weren't true. In a book, he portrayed himself as someone who had been swimming upstream—sometimes against me—to reduce spending.

During the early months of the administration, Stockman did a good job at the Office of Management and Budget, but he was one of the first on our team to begin clamoring for a tax increase, long before the tax cuts had had a chance to begin working their effect into the economy. Moreover,